

Outside India, like in Japan and Europe, 3G laptops are very popular. For rich multimedia experience, a notebook is the best form factor. For example, to see a movie on the Internet, you would want the normal screen of a notebook than a smartphone. And the biggest advantage of 3G-ready laptops is seamless data transfer.

Now that India is getting ready for 3G technology, we thought four to five months back that this is the right time for launching 3G-ready laptops, especially in the higher-end segment. Already the auction process is in place, and we expect at least in the next three months down the line all the players entering the 3G-ready space with 3G-ready SIM cards.

What are the advantages of 3G-ready laptops over competing connectivity options like Wi-Fi and USB modem?

First of all, there is a limitation in you getting connected. I put it otherwise: When it comes to broadband connectivity, you need to have a separate connectivity for that. You need to plug in a wire to get connected to the broadband network. Speed is definitely good for broadband connectivity. But, you need to be constantly at one place. Data card gives you mobility, but it has its own limitation in terms of speed: On a data card, speed is not more than 1 Mbps. While a 3G-ready laptop gives uplink speed of up to 4 Mbps and downlink speed of up to 7 Mbps—the speeds that actually support live video streaming if the laptop has a camera. It also depends on the service provider: Even though the 3G functionality is built into the laptop, this feature should also be supported by the Internet service provider like Vodafone, Bharti or BSNL to get the maximum advantage.

What's the price difference between a 3G-ready laptop and a regular laptop?

A 3G-ready laptop costs about Rs 8000 more than a normal laptop.

What one needs to do in order to enjoy mobile broadband?

Today, whatever high-end laptops we offer in India, they have 3G-ready modules built into them. There is a SIM card provision: If you open the laptop, there is a battery which has a slot for the SIM card. Insert the 3G-ready SIM card provided by the 3G service provider into that slot. But in order to support that, you need a supporting hardware built into the laptop.

You don't need to add any data card. So 3G gives you

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With integrated 3G, one won't always get to choose his carrier (some 3G laptops are available only on a particular telecom operator's network). What could be the solution?

India is actually not ready. We are trying to find the solution. Only BSNL and MTNL are offering 3G-ready SIM cards. But once other telecom players start offering these cards, we would definitely have a pre-analysis done before coming up with the bundling offer with the service provider. Till now, we have already sold out more than 200 units of 3G-ready laptops in India.

What are the most common problems associated with 3G-ready notebooks?

As such, we don't see any problem arising out of the built-in 3G hardware. However, there might be software compatibility issue, which can be sorted out.

Any suggestion for 3G notebook buyers?

For those who are always on the move, 3G is the best option in terms of mobility, hassle-free operation and freedom from options like data cards. It's a one-touch application: just click a button and then the application. The performance depends on the kinds of necessary uplink and downlink speeds being provided by the supporting hardware built into the laptop. However, the necessary service provider also needs to provide these kinds of speeds. There is a specific bandwidth today being provided by them. Everybody talks about different plans: 256 kbps, 1 Mbps or 2 Mbps. There needs to be a specific provision by the service provider for that up to 4 Mbps or 7 Mbps in order to have the user make use of the feature.

How do you see the future of mobile broadband?

Though the competition today is not talking about 3G-ready laptops, maybe six months down the line we'll see competition in the mid- and higher-end segments of notebook PCs. 3G-ready functionality is slightly expensive. When the 3G module is fitted into the laptop, the price of the laptop shoots up. That's why entry-level laptops are not being offered with 3G.

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